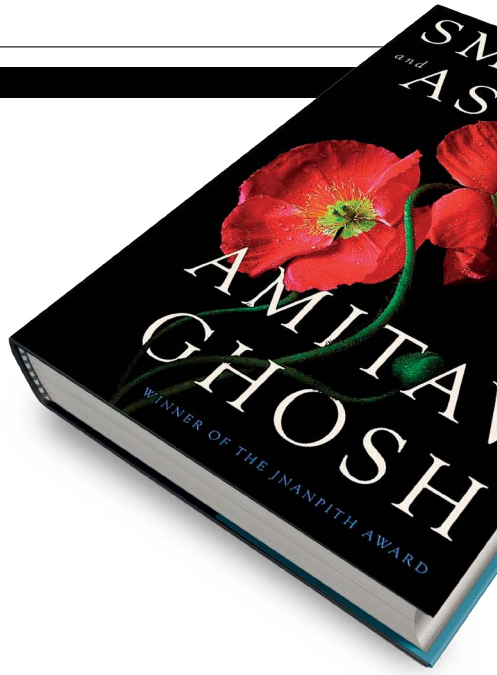
Colonialism is tremendously adaptable. I say 'is' rather than 'was' because colonialism, in its avatar of capitalism, is still very much with us. The only major differences between the past and present are that (a) the beneficiaries no longer need to be exported to the colonies, since our current economic and political institutions do the job of colonising for them, and (b) poor people in coloniser countries are beginning to suspect that they also number among the colonised.

Amitav Ghosh's *Smoke and Ashes* recognises and interrogates that continuity. It is as if Ghosh took the entire vast span of the *Ibis* trilogy and squeezed out the plot and characterisation but kept the epic scope and the novelistic flair. This leaves one principal actor on the stage, towering above any human agency: opium itself. Ghosh utilises the conceit of imagining opium as having an agenda and a strategy of its own: a desire to propagate itself using the willing hands and minds of its human thralls. While this metaphor has great dramatic force, I suspect I am a little too cynical about humans to fully appreciate it. I agree that the poppy has been quite successful in getting humans to grow and spread it, but then so have a vast number of other species we have 'domesticated'. With one caveat: the poppy can change minds, and that is always disturbing.

So, one June afternoon I got on a Zoom call with the author to discuss the new book. Ghosh told me that the book was indeed a 'distillation' of the scholarly spadework he had had to do for the *Ibis* trilogy. He hadn't intended to write it while he was working on the novels, but the raw materials remained in the back of his mind, haunting him. Long after the novels were out in the world, he returned to the history behind them.

In this book, Ghosh paints for us a vivid scene, a place of chaos and confusion: the precarious colony of foreign traders in Canton (Guangzhou) that directed and profited from the opium



WITH SLAVERY, OPIUM IS THE OTHER VICE-TRADE THAT BUILT THE US, AND GHOSH'S STORY SHOWS US THAT THOSE HABITS HAVEN'T BEEN FORGOTTEN BY CORPORATE AMERICA

PHOTOGRAPHY

WHITHER WEATHER

Photographer **Arko Datto**'s work focuses on climate change

The exceptional use of colour and light makes the work of Arko Datto stand out. While there are other photographers who use these two elements with striking effect, this 37-year-old practitioner is one of the few who uses his art to address the exigent issue of climate change.

With degrees in science and hailing from Kolkata—a metropolis that is under threat of drowning if the guard wall of the beleaguered mangrove forests of the Sundarbans is destroyed—Datto took up photography early in life. He needed no introduction as his father was a photojournalist.

Datto started seriously developing long-term projects from 2012. "The climate crisis concerns us all, so everyone should be worried—the government, NGOs and individuals, at both global and local levels. I hope that the work influences all of these levels," he says. Little wonder he admires the writer Amitav Ghosh.

Datto spins stories for the eyes on "seemingly disparate issues like forced migration, techno-fascism, surveillance in the digital panopticon, disappearing islands, nocturnal realms and psychosomatic stress of captive animals". He has held several exhibitions, mostly abroad, published three photo books, and has contributed essays to leading international publications. Datto also enjoys curating exhibitions and has been associated with the Kochi Biennale, Obscura Photography Festival and Chennai Photo Biennale.

About his symbolic use of colour, Datto says: "I work primarily on long-term projects and each one has a specific visual approach and sense of colour that is relevant to that particular concept. I am interested in pushing the possibilities of colour photography. Some projects, for example, use oversaturated colours to create hyper-real worlds, yet others use undersaturated colour schemes to evoke more poetic realms."